

- **Financial help if you go back to school.** According to the G.I. Bill from 2008 (also known as the Post-9/11 G.I. Bill), the government is committed to paying some or all of your college costs for four academic years, including tuition and fees, housing, books, and even (possibly) a moving allowance. After 90 consecutive days of active post-2001 duty in the armed services, National Guard, or Reserves, the government will pick up 40% of the cost of the most expensive public undergraduate school in your state. The benefits scale up the longer you serve; after three years of active duty (or if you get a disability discharge), that same bachelor's degree is effectively *free*.

There are limitations. The program won't pick up all the bills if you're getting an advanced degree or going to a school that is more expensive than any public college in your state. Some private schools will give you a discount to bring their tuition in line with what the government will pay, but you'll still probably have to pay out of pocket. Furthermore, this version of the G.I. Bill usually won't pay for correspondence courses, on-the-job training programs, flight school, apprenticeships, or other nonacademic programs.

One note: If you were in the service before 2009, you may have signed up for the previous version of the G.I. Bill (known as the **Montgomery G.I. Bill**), which operated more like a savings plan. If you've already started contributing, you have the option to either stay in this plan or convert to the new education benefits program described above. It may or may not be a better option for you, so check www.gibill2008.org for all the pros and cons of each version of the G.I. Bill.

- **Additional education dollars.** At enlistment, you may be offered additional money to pay for school down the road if your recruiter is especially impressed with your skills. This is known as a "college fund," a "kicker," or a "supplemental benefit," but it boils down to a lump sum (the amount varies) that the government will add to your other G.I. Bill benefits